



NICE FRANCE

Flavors of the Southern Sun

In Nice's Bay of Angels, the limpid blue water laps the shore, but when the summer sun is pulsing like a furnace, it's the old town that beckons. Shade is offered by the pedestrian-friendly alleys with their pale facades and myriad galleries, while bars and bistros provide refreshment. A freshly made *salade niçoise*, a taste of sea and land, perfectly captures the essence of the city.



Nice has long lured artists and the idly affluent escaping a wintry north, attracted by the pastel-colored old town, the glitzy marina lifestyle, the palm-trimmed seafront, and the gloriously fresh food dished up in bistros, seaside cafés, and deluxe hotels. The city is a delicious culinary and cultural combination, proudly flaunting the influence of successive waves of outsiders. The Greeks were here, the Romans, too, and the northern Italians via the powerful Counts of Savoy. Nice finally passed into French hands in 1860 but the strong Italian influence, especially tableside, remains. This is, after all, the birthplace of ravioli and of Garibaldi.

The British, who have been visiting since the 1730s, also left their mark. Nice became the sundrenched sandbox of choice for aristocrats in the 19th century, even entertaining Queen Victoria. Luxury hotels sprang up to accommodate them while they built villas and raised a subscription to erect a walkway by the sea, the aptly named Promenade des Anglais.

When it comes to living and cooking, the Niçois keep it simple. You won't find rich sauces blanketing food; instead, it's subtle seasoning with an emphasis on newly picked, freshly caught, just made, and preferably

enjoyed al fresco. There's no mistaking, then, that *salade niçoise* is a dish born of Nice. Each ingredient evokes the sun-soaked Mediterranean city, from the fragrant summer tomatoes to the salty, sea-kissed anchovies.

Some argue that a true *niçoise* contains only tomatoes, artichoke hearts, bell peppers, tiny, black *niçoise* olives, and anchovy fillets, dressed with rich local olive oil and fresh herbs: no vinegar – and certainly no tuna or lettuce. Others insist on tuna – canned, not fresh – but counsel against hard-boiled eggs. An infamous ex-city mayor turned cookbook author was adamant that potatoes, or any kind of cooked vegetables (those pesky green beans, for example), had no place in his *niçoise* salad bowl; and it's either tuna or anchovies, never the two together.

Today's innovative chefs insist, however, that the humble *niçoise* is at its best when it takes its lead from the seasons. Thus arugula, radishes, ruby-ringed onions, fava beans, and even thinly sliced cucumber may stake their claim among the flavor-infused tomatoes, olives, tuna, anchovies, and just-cooked eggs. And therein lies the key. The supremely generous Côte d'Azur climate enriches both the cuisine and the city so that, whatever its makeup, the signature dish of this southern city tastes like summer on a plate.

A Day in Nice

This historic seaside resort, nicknamed *Nice la Belle* (Nice the Beautiful), has buzz and beauty in spades, and there's plenty to see when the beach doesn't beckon.

MORNING Opt for a lazy café breakfast in **cours Saleya** and watch market vendors spin their spiel. Take to the cobbled alleyways, stopping at **Palais Lascaris** to glimpse how the very well-heeled once lived. Catch the elevator to **Castle Hill** for a Nice panorama, via **Tour Bellanda**, where Berlioz composed his *King Lear* overture.

AFTERNOON Hike up to **Cimiez** to pore over Henri Matisse's paintings, drawings, and sculptures in the **Musée Matisse**, the 17th-century villa in which the artist spent his last 34 years. Wander the nearby **Franciscan monastery** and its gardens, and on to the cemetery where Matisse and his fellow artist Raoul Dufy are buried.

EVENING Come sunset, walk or cycle the **Promenade des Anglais** along the cherubic **Bay of Angels**, past the swaying palms, pausing for a sundowner in the Relais bar of the flamboyant **Hotel Negresco**.

Essentials

GETTING THERE

Buses run from **Nice airport** to the central train station, with trains to Monaco, Cannes, Marseille, and Paris. Get around the city on foot, by bus, taxi, or free *vélo bleu* bicycles.

WHERE TO STAY

Villa la Tour (inexpensive) is a family-run gem in the heart of the old town. www.villa-la-tour.com
The Hotel Windsor (moderate) is full of contemporary art. www.hotelwindsornice.com
La Perouse (expensive) is a chic oasis looking over the Bay. www.hotel-la-perouse.com

TOURIST INFORMATION

5 Prom des Anglais; www.nicetourisme.com

